

What is Anthropology?



What is Anthropology?

Anthropology is the scientific study of humans: our evolution and cultural development, and our biology, culture, and use of language today. It is a broad social science that spans the entire history of our species and our earliest ancestors to the present day. Anthropology uses systematic approaches for the study of humans—especially the comparative approach, in which the **culture** (present or past) or organism (e.g., a fossil human ancestor) is systematically compared with others known to identify meaningful similarities and differences that speak to broader questions of why an organism evolved the way it did, or why a specific aspect of culture is present in a certain human group.

Culture is the sum of the social behavior practiced by humans. Culture is generally used to describe human societies exclusively, although arguments have been made that our close relatives, the great apes, possess aspects of culture, as well. Culture includes a set of learned norms and practices that are diverse over time and space. Archaeologists may use the term "culture" to describe the people who left behind a set of material remains with similarities over a span of time and space—for example, the Bell Beaker Culture (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Bell_Beaker_culture). This term is usually used in prehistoric settings in which we do not know what people called themselves.

The Four Subfields of Anthropology

In the United States and Canada, anthropology is divided into four subfields of study, each a major research discipline. These subfields have distinct aims, research methods, and data studied, but all aim to address central anthropological questions about the origins and development of humans and our societies.

Sociocultural Anthropology

Alternately termed "social anthropology" (as often in Europe) or "cultural anthropology" (in the US), this subfield is concerned with human societies of the present or recent, anthropologically documented, past. Sociocultural anthropology is the study of relationships among individuals and groups and how people make sense of their worlds. While sociocultural anthropologists may conduct explicitly comparative research, studying multiple human societies in order to compare them, many focus on one group or region and write rich **ethnographies** that detail how a particular aspect of social relationships functions within that society. For example, anthropologists might study how modern Maya of the Yucatan farm in order to understand rituals conducted at various points on the farming calendar, or how families in Vietnam show grief and sorrow upon the loss of a family member. In all of these cases, however, anthropologists compare the facet of the culture they study with other cultures previously studied by anthropologists, in order to understand commonalities of the human experience.

Ethnography is a key anthropological tool for the study of culture. Through observation of the behavior, actions, and stated beliefs of people, aspects of their shared culture are determined. Although ethnography most often relies on in-person observation, often as a participant in cultural activities, it also can draw on the analysis of documentary records, whether written or visual.

Biological Anthropology

Formerly often termed "physical anthropology," this discipline is the evolutionary study of humans. It originated in the study of the fossils of human ancestors—hence, the original emphasis on physical remains—but today, biological anthropology involves research topics as diverse as the study of human genetics (modern and ancient), of behavioral adaptations as evolved traits, and of nonhuman primates. The purpose of these various modes of study is the same: to learn about how humans evolved and how our evolutionary history shapes aspects of culture, behavior, and health today. For example, the study of how gorillas and chimpanzees use tools helps us to understand the biological and cognitive limitations of early human ancestor species. The study of

the genetic basis of specific traits (for example, lactase persistence, which allows adults to digest mammal milk) helps us to understand the environment in which our ancestors evolved and how that influenced our diet today.

Linguistic Anthropology

Linguistic anthropology is the study of the social function of language. Unlike linguistics, which studies the structure and evolution of languages, linguistic anthropology aims to study the social context of language use. This subfield was originally concerned with documenting new and endangered languages, such as the thousands of indigenous languages of New Guinea or the Amazon Basin, a practice that has become increasingly difficult as languages have been lost. Linguistic anthropologists often work to understand the role of specific language elements within a social setting; for example, studying the back-and-forth discussion between a child and a mother in suburban Los Angeles about what the child will eat for dinner might tell us more about both processes of negotiation in the contemporary US and how discussions of food are distinct from negotiations about clothing or playtime.

Archaeology

You already know about archaeology! But you should be aware that in the US and Canada, many types of archaeology are considered to fall into a subfield of anthropology—namely, those that are explicitly comparative or scientific in structure, as well as the study of cultures of the Americas, both ancient and historical. Classical and Near Eastern archaeology (such as Egyptology, the field that studies ancient Egyptian art, language, and history, as well as archaeology) often fall outside this category and are considered branches of Classical or Ancient Near Eastern studies. In Europe and most of the rest of the world, however, archaeology is considered a separate discipline from anthropology, and all archaeologists would be gathered into a single academic unit within a university. BU has both models: a Department of Anthropology with several archaeologists among the faculty, and an Archaeology Program, an interdisciplinary program that brings together faculty from the Departments of Anthropology, Classical Studies, History of Art & Architecture, and Religion in one program!